Evangelize

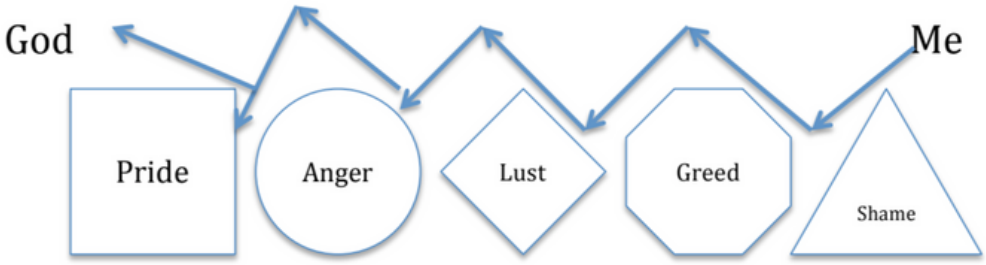


Gospel vs. Religion

What things about you do you wish God just didn't know or didn't see? These are often things that separate us from God. The shapes below represent these things.

Religion

When religion sees these things it tries to fix them through self-effort. Religion sees these issues as obstacles to be overcome. The religious person says, "I have to be better" and so they try to fix them through "being better" as seen in the arrows.



What does this result in?

1. Depression – Sure we'll make some progress in some areas but ultimately we will be overwhelmed by the progress that we cannot make. This results in depression as we throw up our hands in despair and quit since we cannot "make the grade".

2. Pride – For some of us we will make strides in some areas yet we will become frustrated with those who do not or choose not to make the same progress. This results in pride as we will see ourselves as better than these people. Think of the Pharisees in the time of Jesus and how they viewed others.

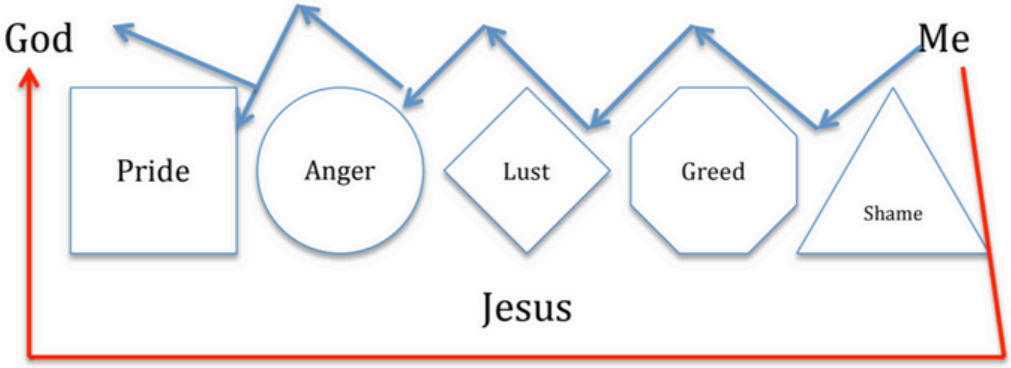
3. Unforgiveness – Similar to pride, there will be a lack of forgiveness on our part for those who choose not to grow. Why? Because we overcame it, they didn't, and we are tired of their excuses.

4. Duty – Our desire to change is driven by a duty to please God. We do it because we have to as we seek to earn his love or favor.

The Gospel or "Good News"

On the other hand the Gospel has nothing to do with you earning it. As the red line demonstrates (next page), Christ sees all of our mess, our shame, and our guilt yet He picks us up and places us right next to God. How? What about our shame, our sin? Well when God sees us now, He no longer sees our sin and shame, instead all He sees is Jesus' perfection. How? Because we choose to believe that Jesus died upon the cross for our sin/shame and rose from the dead on the third day. His perfection covers our imperfection. Ephesians 2:4-10 (next page) illustrates this as Paul tells us that God was rich in mercy so he covered our transgressions in Christ so that we may now be alive and seated next to Him in the heavenly realm. How do we receive this acceptance, this perfection? By faith in Jesus' sacrifice. He did it, we did nothing, and so we now gain everything. As verses eight and nine make clear, none of our full acceptance comes by works, it is all by faith in Christ so that none of us can boast of what we have done. In other words, there is no religion, no earning it.

Gospel vs. Religion



Ephesian 2:4-10 (NLT)

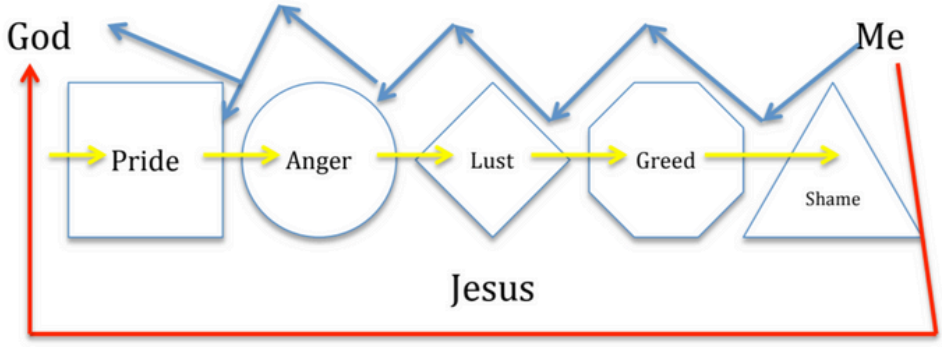
4 But God is so rich in mercy, and he loved us so much, 5 that even though we were dead because of our sins, he gave us life when he raised Christ from the dead. (It is only by God's grace that you have been saved!) 6 For he raised us from the dead along with Christ and seated us with him in the heavenly realms because we are united with Christ Jesus. 7 So God can point to us in all future ages as examples of the incredible wealth of his grace and kindness toward us, as shown in all he has done for us who are united with Christ Jesus.

8 God saved you by his grace when you believed. And you can't take credit for this; it is a gift from God. 9 Salvation is not a reward for the good things we have done, so none of us can boast about it. 10 For we are God's masterpiece. He has created us anew in Christ Jesus, so we can do the good things he planned for us long ago

What does this result in?
1. Joy – Instead of being weighed down in despair by all we have to do to earn acceptance, we now have joy because we are fully accepted and fully loved.
2. Humility – Humility is "passion for God" whereas pride is "passion for self". Since Jesus paid it all and made me whole, I now have passion for him. I want to champion Him and not myself since He fully loves and accepts me.
3. Forgiveness – Since Jesus has fully forgiven me I am called to forgive others. If in his perfection He can forgive all my mess, then how can I in my imperfection not forgive another imperfect person?
4. Love – The opposite of duty. I don't seek to follow God and be like him because I have to, I do it because I want to. If you love your spouse you don't have to put reminders around the house to tell you to be affectionate, tell them you love them, or serve them. You just do it. Why? Because you love them.

Yet things do not stop there....

Now that we are fully accepted by God He is not content to leave us alone. He knows all our sin and shame, He knows our mess, yet He wants to transform it. He desires to make us into who He created us to be. As a result God will chisel away at those shameful parts for the rest of your life as represented by the yellow line. As Ephesians 2:10 states, "We are His workmanship, created to do good works in Christ Jesus". We are fully accepted and at the same time a work in progress as the Holy Spirit is transforming us into God's "workmanship". We are like a messy house on "Hoarders", God owns the property no matter what and He wants to clean us out. It will take a while and there is no way the job will be completed on this side of eternity, but nonetheless He is at work. Then when we are in His presence we will finally be what God intended: fully loved, fully accepted, and our "house" clean and beautiful.



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